

Defensible average deal values for documentary escrow

Year-1 base cases and Year-2 to Year-5 growth assumptions for Tier A, Tier B and Tier C document verification.

Prepared for Blockmediary
11 August 2026
Primary launch market: UAE

Recommended Year 1

A £35k

B £30k

C £30k

Base growth: 10% / 8% / 5%

EXECUTIVE CONCLUSION

Use £35k for Tier A and £30k for both Tier B and Tier C

The evidence does **not** support a mechanical Tier A > Tier B > Tier C transaction-size ladder. Document maturity and transaction value are correlated only indirectly through customer and sector mix. The recommended base case gives Tier A a modest £5k premium because larger firms adopt eBL more frequently, while holding Tier B and Tier C equal because paper documentation remains common in high-value trade and Tier C pricing makes genuinely small deals unattractive.

TIER A YEAR 1 £35,000 \$47,000 at 10 Aug 2026 FX; 10% annual growth; medium-low confidence	TIER B YEAR 1 £30,000 \$41,000; 8% annual growth; medium confidence	TIER C YEAR 1 £30,000 \$41,000; 5% annual growth; medium-low confidence
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Decision standard. These are conservative launch-cohort averages, not addressable-market averages. They sit above a broad Dubai customs-declaration proxy (~£16k), around the more relevant maritime and India export-document proxies (~£30k-£39k), and well below chamber certificate-of-origin proxies (~£79k-£84k). [S2] [S3] [S4] [S5] [S6] [S7] [S8]

Blockmediary deal-value recommendation: evidence → judgement → operating model

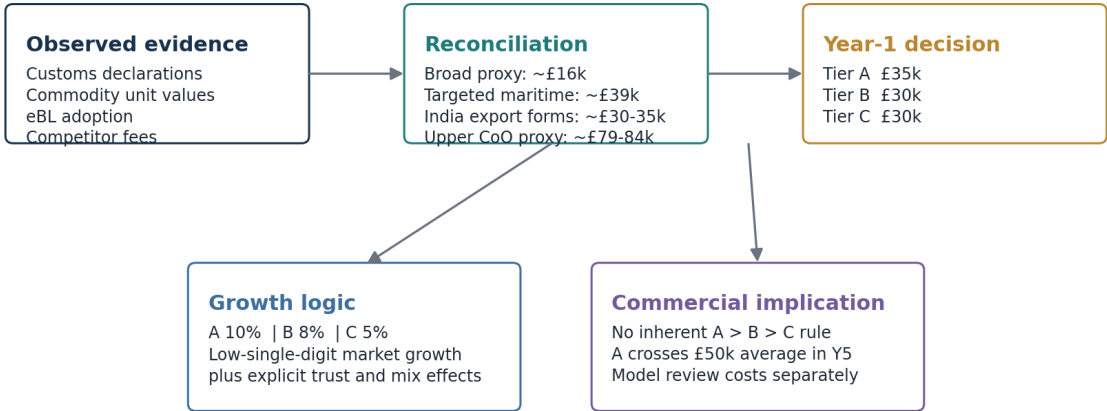


Figure 1. Triangulated evidence produces a modest Tier A launch premium, equal Tier B and C bases, and tier-specific growth assumptions.

Contents

1. Five-year recommendation

2. Evidence method and limitations

3. Top-down evidence

4. Bottom-up shipment evidence

5. Document maturity and transaction size

6. Tier-by-tier rationale

7. Unit economics and comparables

8. Model implications

9. Research gaps

10. Final decision statement

Appendix A. Evidence table

Appendix B. Direct source links

1. Five-year recommendation

Recommended values in GBP

Tier	Y1 average deal	Y2	Y3	Y4	Y5	Annual growth	Confidence
Tier A	£35,000	£38,500	£42,500	£46,500	£51,000	10%	Medium-low
Tier B	£30,000	£32,500	£35,000	£38,000	£41,000	8%	Medium
Tier C	£30,000	£31,500	£33,000	£34,500	£36,500	5%	Medium-low

Displayed values are rounded to the nearest £500 for commercial use. The workbook retains exact compounding.

USD equivalents at the fixed exchange-rate date

Tier	Y1	Y2	Y3	Y4	Y5
Tier A	\$47,000	\$52,000	\$57,000	\$63,000	\$69,000
Tier B	\$41,000	\$44,000	\$47,000	\$51,000	\$55,000
Tier C	\$41,000	\$43,000	\$45,000	\$47,000	\$49,000

Exchange rates use the Central Bank of the UAE’s rates last updated on 10 August 2026: USD/AED 3.6725 and GBP/AED 4.959487, implying GBP/USD 1.3504. [\[S1\]](#)

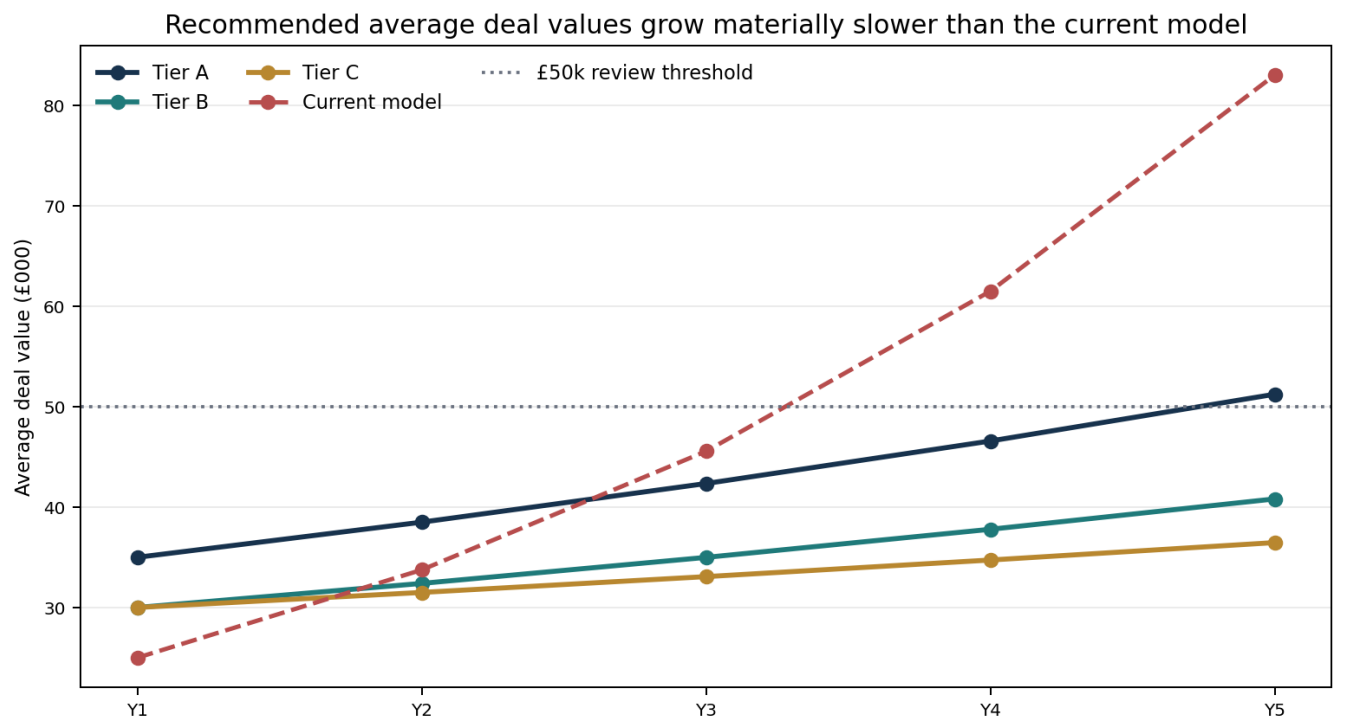


Figure 2. Recommended values compared with the current shared model and the £50,000 automatic-verdict threshold.

Sensitivity table

Tier	Case	Y1	Annual growth	Y5	Average threshold crossing
Tier A	Low	£25,000	4%	£29,000	Not by Y5
Tier A	Base	£35,000	10%	£51,000	Y5
Tier A	High	£50,000	15%	£87,500	Y1
Tier B	Low	£20,000	3%	£22,500	Not by Y5
Tier B	Base	£30,000	8%	£41,000	Not by Y5
Tier B	High	£45,000	13%	£73,500	Y2
Tier C	Low	£20,000	2%	£21,500	Not by Y5
Tier C	Base	£30,000	5%	£36,500	Not by Y5
Tier C	High	£45,000	10%	£66,000	Y3

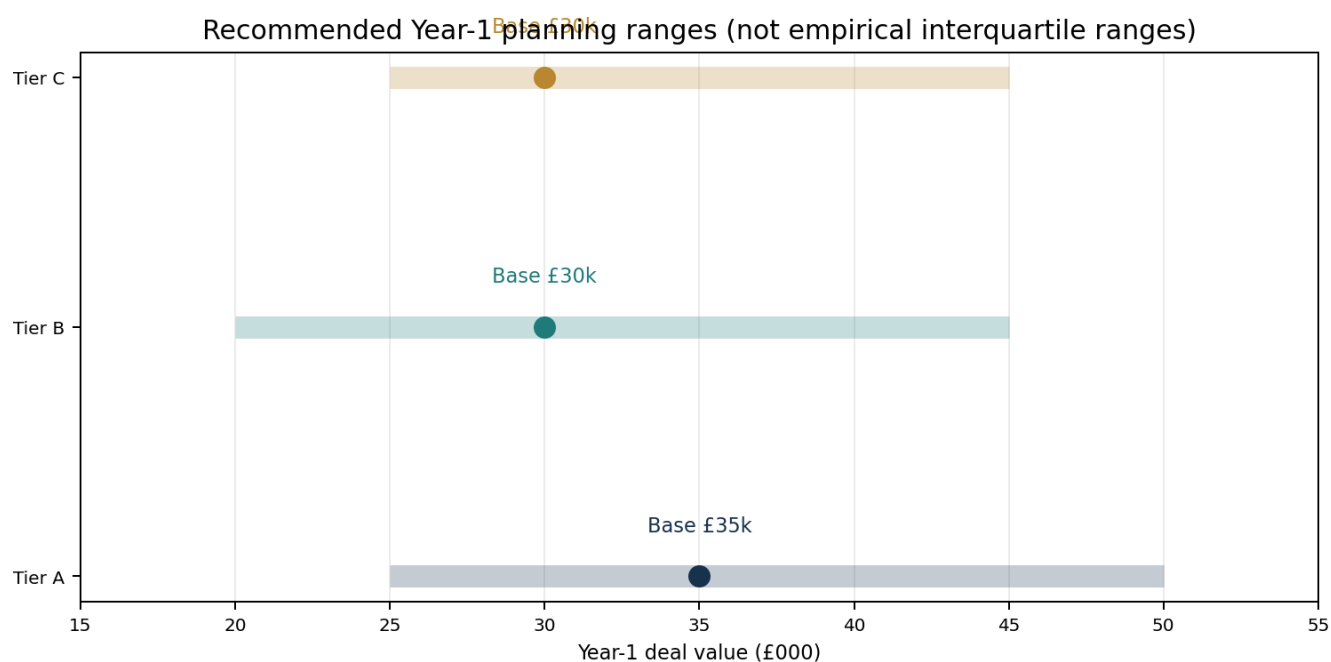


Figure 3. The Year-1 planning bands are decision ranges, not empirical interquartile ranges.

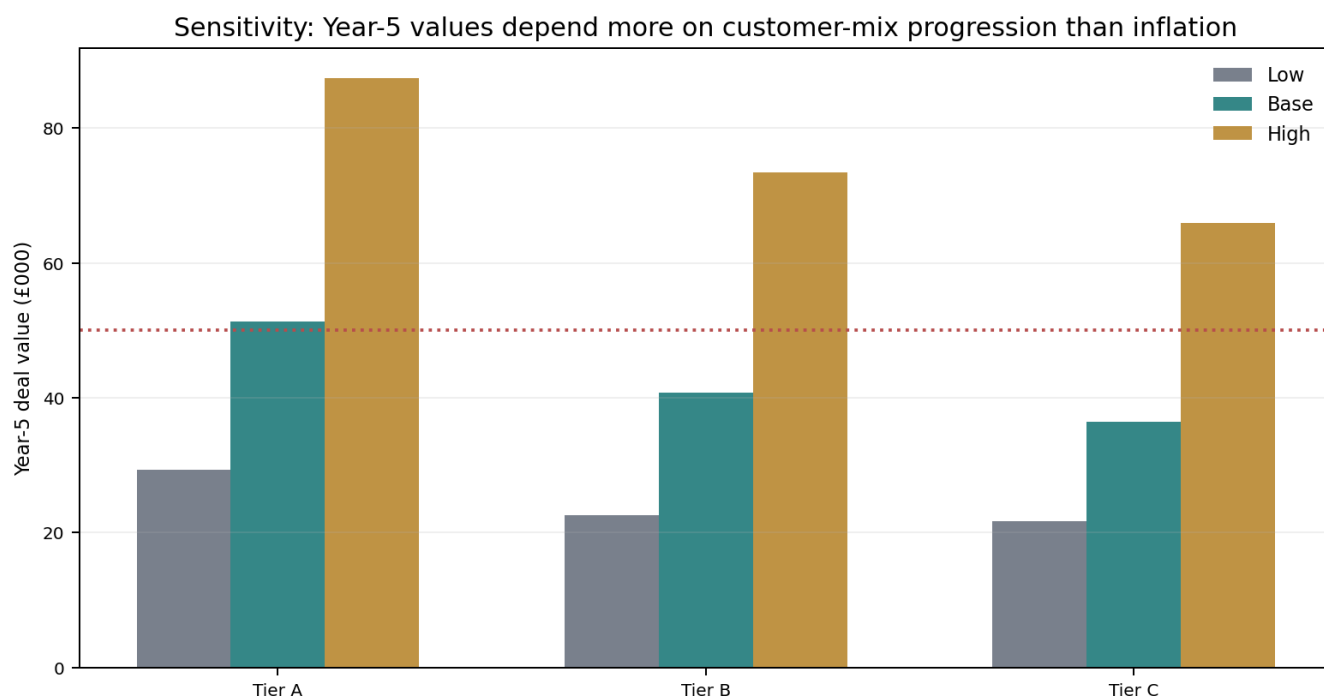


Figure 4. Low, base and high Year-5 outcomes under explicit starting-value and growth assumptions.

Why the growth rates differ

World merchandise trade volume is forecast to grow only 1.9% in 2026 and 2.6% in 2027, while the IMF expected UAE inflation around 2% over the medium term. Those facts support a low-single-digit nominal baseline, not 35% annual average-deal growth. [\[S21\]](#) [\[S22\]](#)

The recommended rates therefore use an explicit planning decomposition: roughly 3% for nominal trade-value growth, plus 7% for Tier A, 5% for Tier B and 2% for Tier C from repeat-customer trust, larger customer acquisition and mix progression. These uplifts are **assumptions**, not observed causal estimates. Tier C grows slowest because successful customers and document flows should migrate toward B or A rather than making the manual tier indefinitely larger.

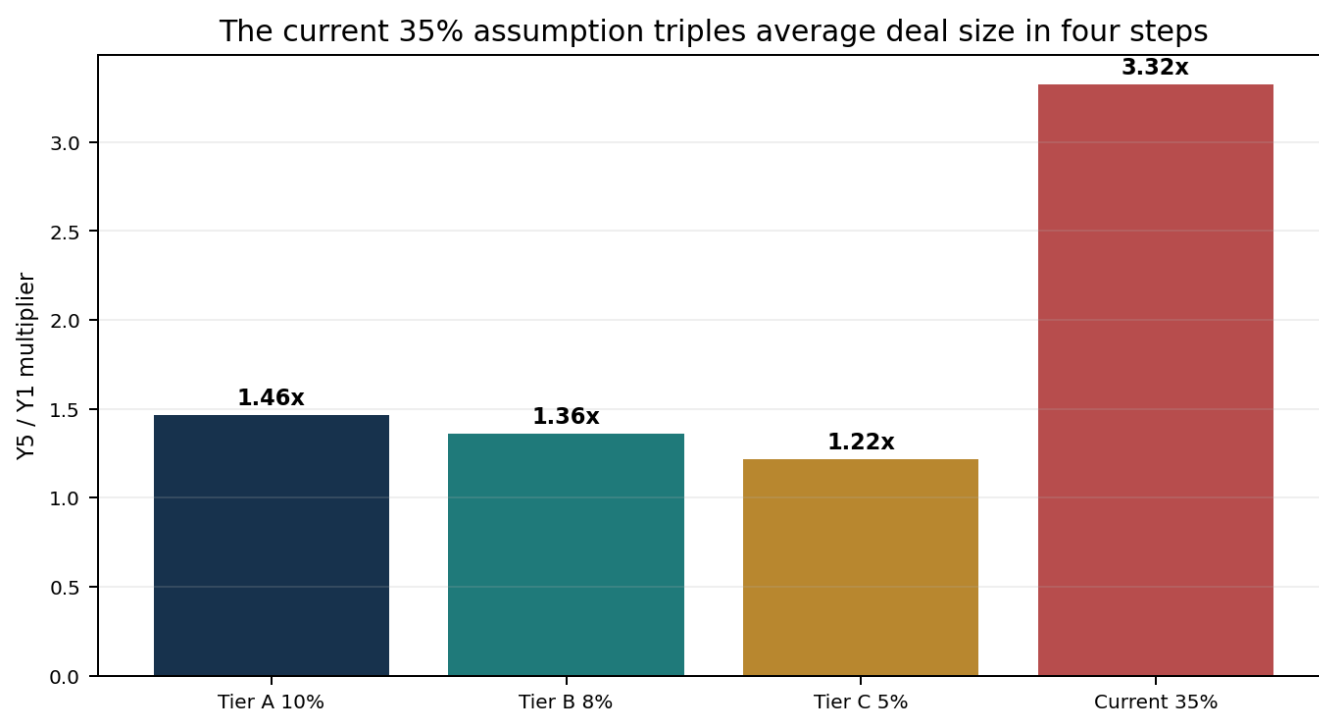


Figure 14. Four annual steps at 35% produce a 3.32x multiplier, compared with 1.22x-1.46x under the recommended cases.

Recommended growth explicitly separates market growth from company-specific progression

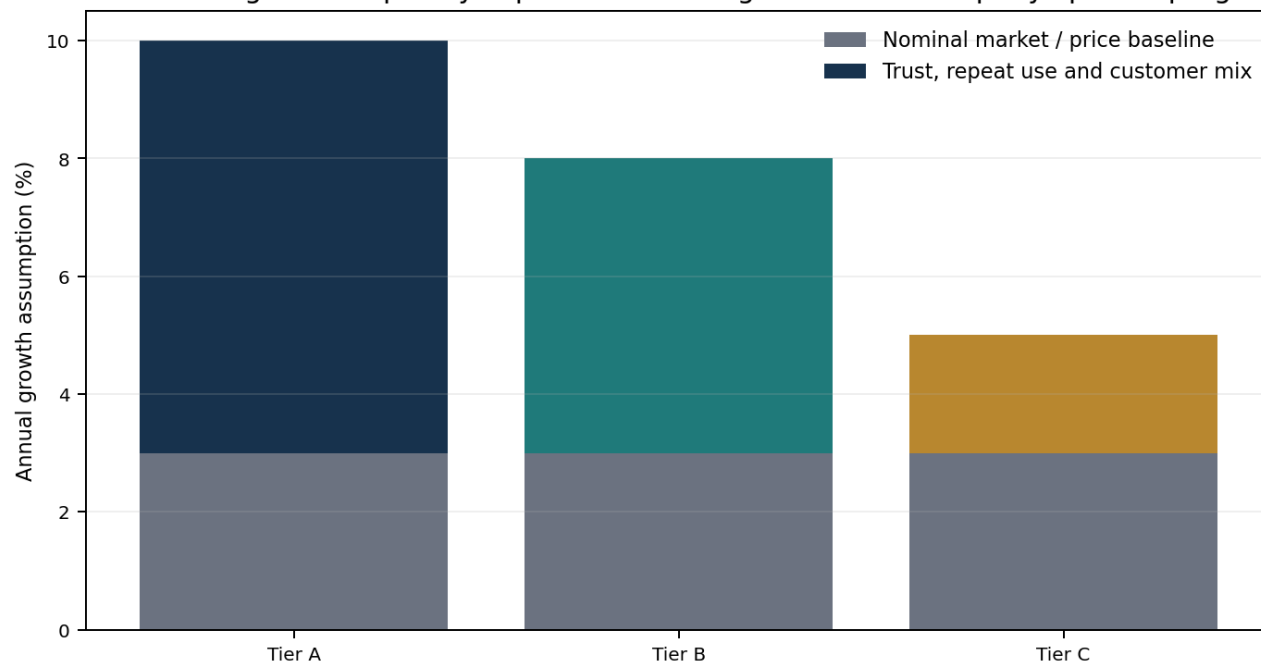


Figure 15. Planning decomposition of the recommended annual growth assumptions.

2. Evidence method and limitations

Statistical limitation. No public source found provides a transaction-level dataset linking deal value, SME status, corridor, sector, shipment mode and Tier A/B/C verification method. A true tier-level mean, median or interquartile range cannot be calculated from public data. Aggregate value-per-document ratios are presented as proxies; planning ranges are not relabelled as empirical quartiles.

Three approaches were reconciled

1. **Top-down.** Official trade values were divided only by named denominators such as customs declarations, Shipping Bills, Bills of Entry or certificates of origin. The denominator and its limitations are stated in every row.
2. **Bottom-up.** WITS/UN Comtrade values and physical quantities were used to derive unit values for target-sector goods. Explicit shipment-quantity assumptions then produce illustrative transaction ranges.
3. **Comparable product.** Blockmediary's fee schedule was compared with current general escrow prices and UAE documentary-credit fee schedules. Product differences are retained: a bank LC includes a bank undertaking, while Blockmediary is prefunded escrow and does not lend.

How observed facts and assumptions are separated

Label	Meaning	Example
Observed	Directly reported by an official or primary source.	Dubai Customs processed more than 26.5m declarations in 2023.
Derived proxy	Arithmetic using an observed numerator and denominator.	AED12.133bn / 62,454 declarations = about £39k per declaration.
Planning assumption	A judgement required because public data do not identify shipment size or launch-customer mix.	6-12 tonnes of metal furniture per illustrative shipment.
Recommendation	The reconciled commercial decision for Blockmediary.	Tier B Year-1 average = £30k.

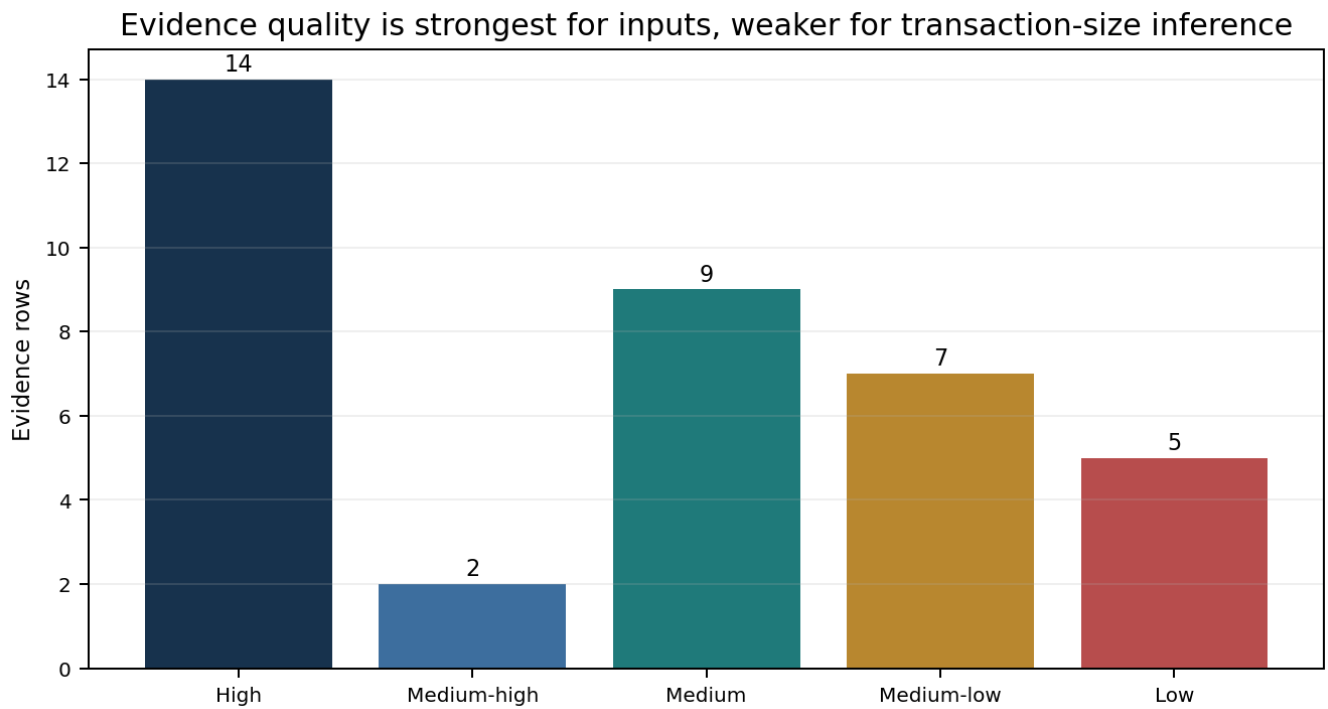


Figure 18. The evidence base is strong for official inputs and weaker where shipment quantities or tier-level inferences are required.

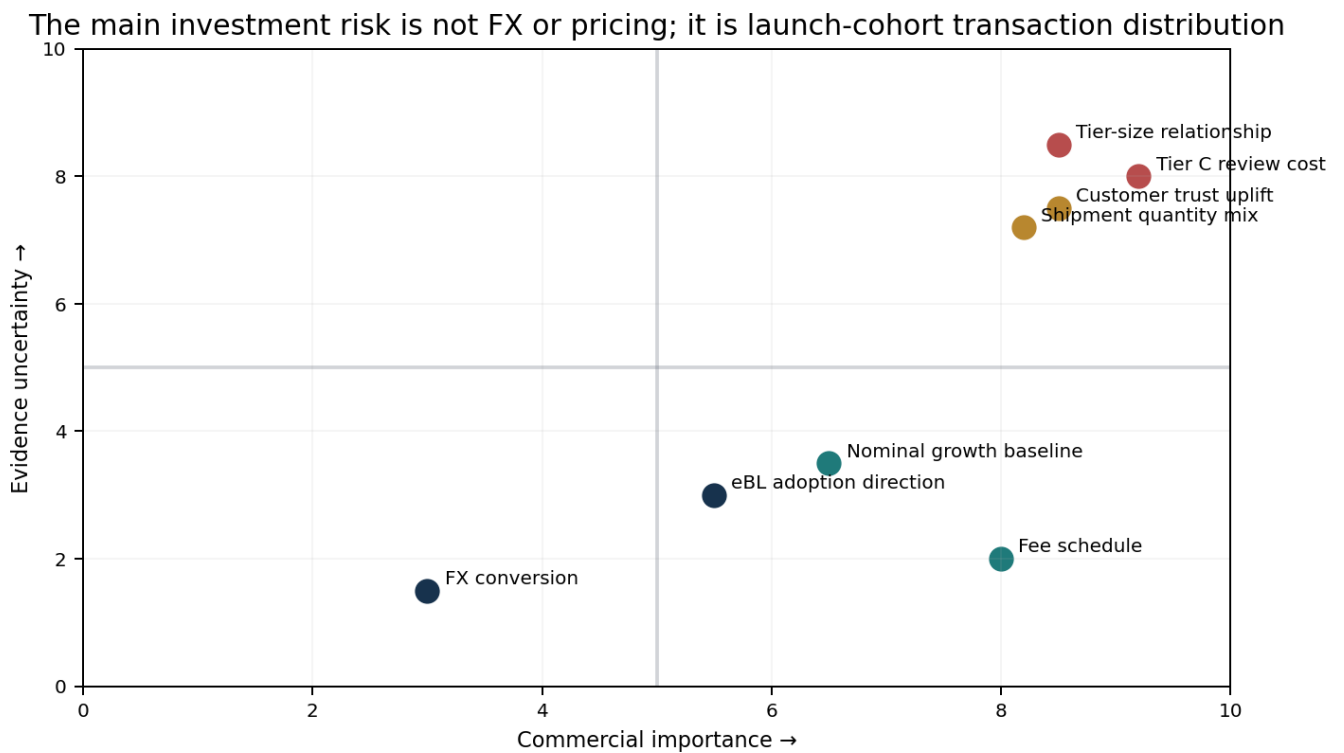


Figure 19. The most important unresolved variables are launch-cohort deal distributions, trust uplift and manual-review cost.

3. Top-down evidence

The official ratios do not converge to one “correct” average because the denominators represent different events. That dispersion is useful: it identifies a lower broad-market anchor, a more relevant maritime/export-document range, and an upper exporter/chamber range.

Proxy	GBP	USD	Denominator	Source	Quality	Limitation
Dubai broad customs-declaration proxy (2023)	£15,894	\$21,464	customs declarations	[S2] [S3]	Medium-low	Numerator is inferred from a zone share; declarations include courier, re-exports, transit and multiple declarations per commercial deal.
Hamriyah + Deira maritime declaration proxy (Q1-Q3 2023)	£39,172	\$52,899	customs declarations	[S4]	Medium	Only two smaller ports and nine months; excludes Jebel Ali; declaration is not necessarily one trade deal.
Dubai Chamber export/re-export per certificate of origin (2024)	£78,909	\$106,561	certificates of origin	[S5]	Medium-low	Includes large firms; a certificate of origin is not a one-to-one transaction denominator.
Dubai Chamber export/re-export per certificate of origin (2025)	£84,351	\$113,911	certificates of origin	[S6]	Medium-low	Includes large firms; a certificate of origin is not a one-to-one transaction denominator.
India non-petroleum exports per Shipping Bill	£30,109	\$40,661	Shipping Bills	[S7] [S8]	Medium	Trade total and annual document count are broad national figures and may not cover identical periods; Shipping Bill is not necessarily one invoice.
India all merchandise exports per Shipping Bill	£35,208	\$47,546	Shipping Bills	[S7] [S8]	Medium	Includes oil, large corporates and sectors outside Blockmediary targets; Shipping Bill is not necessarily one invoice.
India merchandise imports per Bill of Entry	£96,970	\$130,953	Bills of Entry	[S7] [S8]	Medium-low	Includes oil, gold and large industrial imports; Bills of Entry can aggregate or split commercial transactions.

Top-down proxies span a wide range because denominators describe different trade events

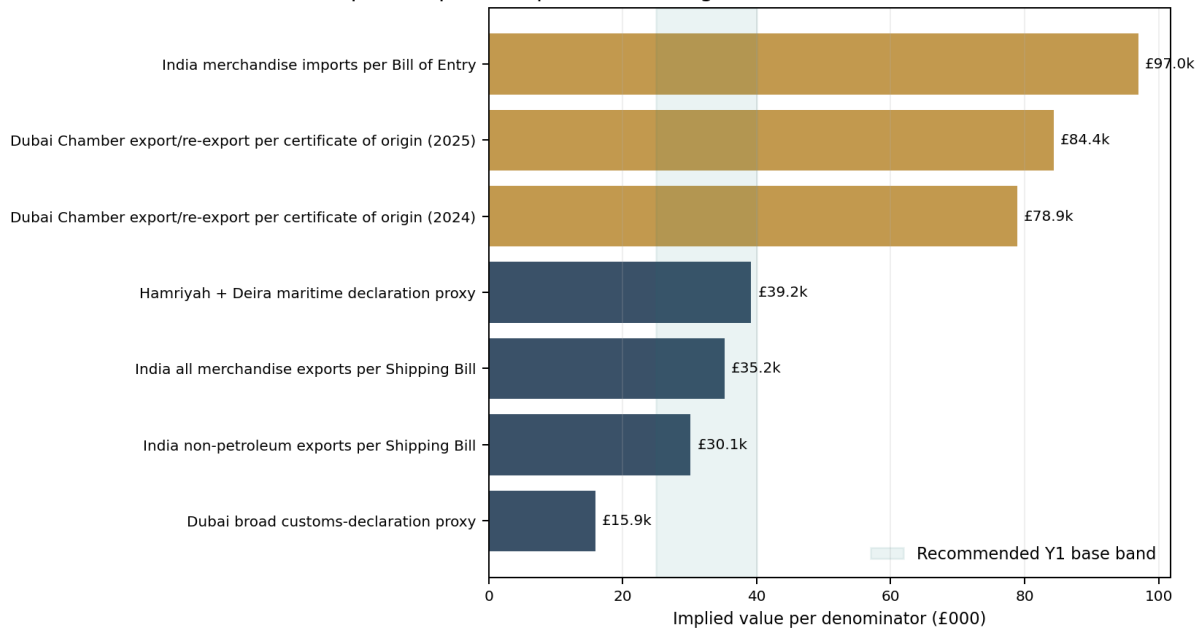


Figure 5. Official aggregate ratios range from broad declaration activity to exporter-oriented certificate-of-origin activity.

Interpretation

- **Broad Dubai activity: ~£16k.** Dubai non-oil trade is inferred from DIEZ's AED282bn representing 13.5% of Dubai non-oil trade, then divided by more than 26.5m declarations. This is too broad to use directly because the denominator includes many small and administrative customs events. [\[S2\]](#) [\[S3\]](#)
- **Maritime/wholesale activity: ~£39k.** Hamriyah and Deira ports processed 62,454 declarations worth AED12.133bn in the first nine months of 2023. This is closer to Blockmediary's intended goods-trade profile but excludes Jebel Ali and covers only two ports. [\[S4\]](#)
- **India export forms: ~£30k-£35k.** India's 9.2m annual Shipping Bills combined with FY2024-25 export values imply about £30k per non-petroleum Shipping Bill and £35k across all merchandise exports. This is one of the strongest anchors for UAE-India SME exports, though a Shipping Bill is not necessarily one invoice. [\[S7\]](#) [\[S8\]](#)
- **Exporter/chamber upper anchor: ~£79k-£84k.** Dubai Chamber export/re-export value divided by certificates of origin is biased toward established exporters and larger firms. The implied ratio increased about 6.9% from 2024 to 2025—well below 35%, but one year is not a forecast. [\[S5\]](#) [\[S6\]](#)

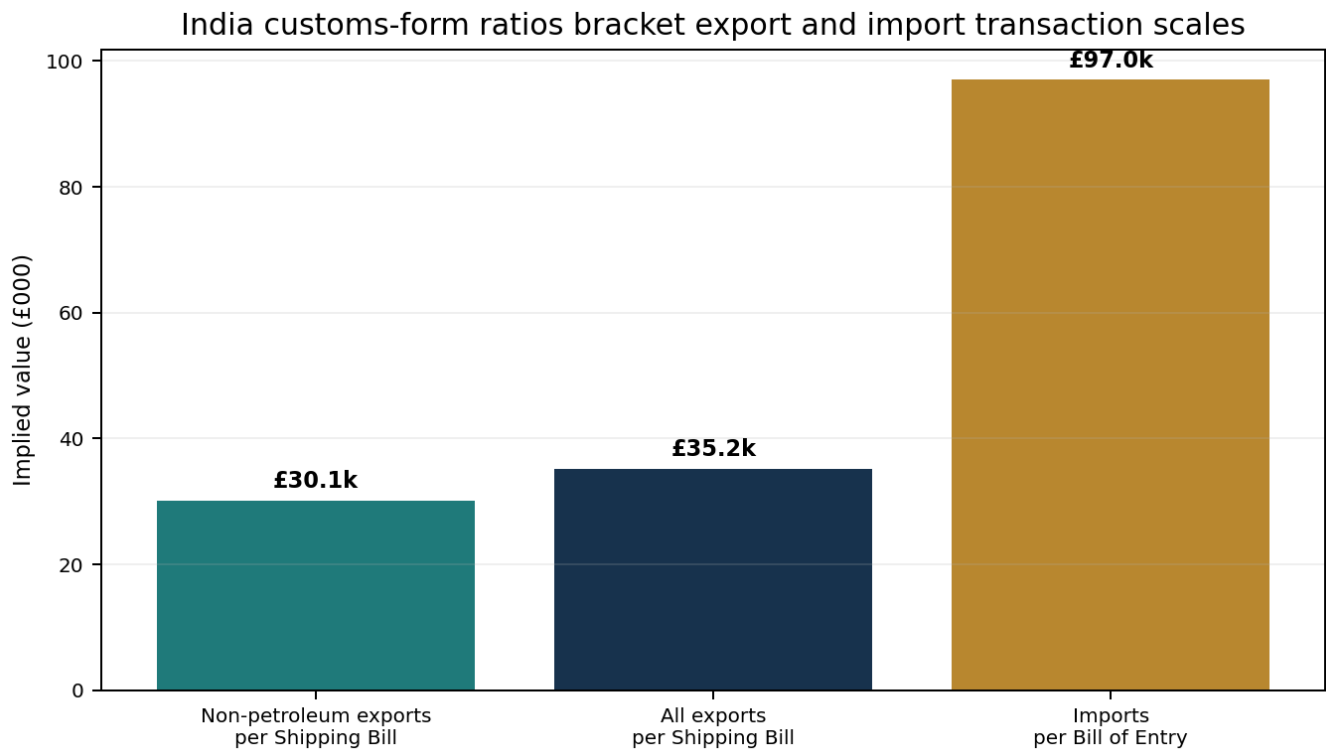


Figure 7. India export and import ratios show why transaction direction and goods mix materially affect value.

Corridor totals are context, not average-deal evidence

UAE-India non-oil trade was about AED180bn (\$49bn), UAE-Türkiye trade exceeded \$20bn in 2023, and Saudi-Pakistan trade was reported at \$5.4bn. None of those sources supplies a transaction, shipment or invoice denominator, so the totals establish corridor relevance only. [\[S26\]](#) [\[S27\]](#) [\[S28\]](#)

4. Bottom-up shipment evidence

Commodity unit values show why sector and shipment quantity dominate document format. A full container of low-value-density goods can be smaller than an LCL shipment of electronic components, while one item of manufactured equipment can already exceed £50k.

Goods	Corridor	Customs unit value	Planning quantity	Illustrative GBP range	Source	Limitation
Cotton T-shirts	India → UAE	\$6.50/item	Planning shipment of 5,000-15,000 items.	£24,063-£72,189	[S9]	Customs unit value is an aggregate across qualities and contracts; shipment quantity is a planning assumption.
Large diesel generating set	India → UAE	\$73,073.22/item	One generator per transaction.	£54,111-£54,111	[S10]	HS line aggregates different specifications; one-item assumption may not map to one invoice.
Metal furniture	Türkiye → UAE	\$3.87/kg	Planning load of 6-12 tonnes.	£17,191-£34,382	[S11]	Weight-to-value average mixes product grades; load range is an assumption and may be LCL or partial FCL.
Cotton bed linen	Pakistan → KSA	\$11.06/kg	Planning load of 5-10 tonnes.	£40,966-£81,932	[S12]	Customs unit value is an aggregate; load range is an assumption.
Rice	Pakistan → KSA	\$1.17/kg	Planning load of 20-25 tonnes.	£17,295-£21,619	[S13]	Rice is outside the primary target sectors and is included only as a low-value-density floor proxy.
Electrical relays	India → UAE	\$51.54/kg	Planning shipment of 0.5-1.5 tonnes.	£19,082-£57,247	[S14]	Customs unit value mixes product specifications; shipment weight is a planning assumption.

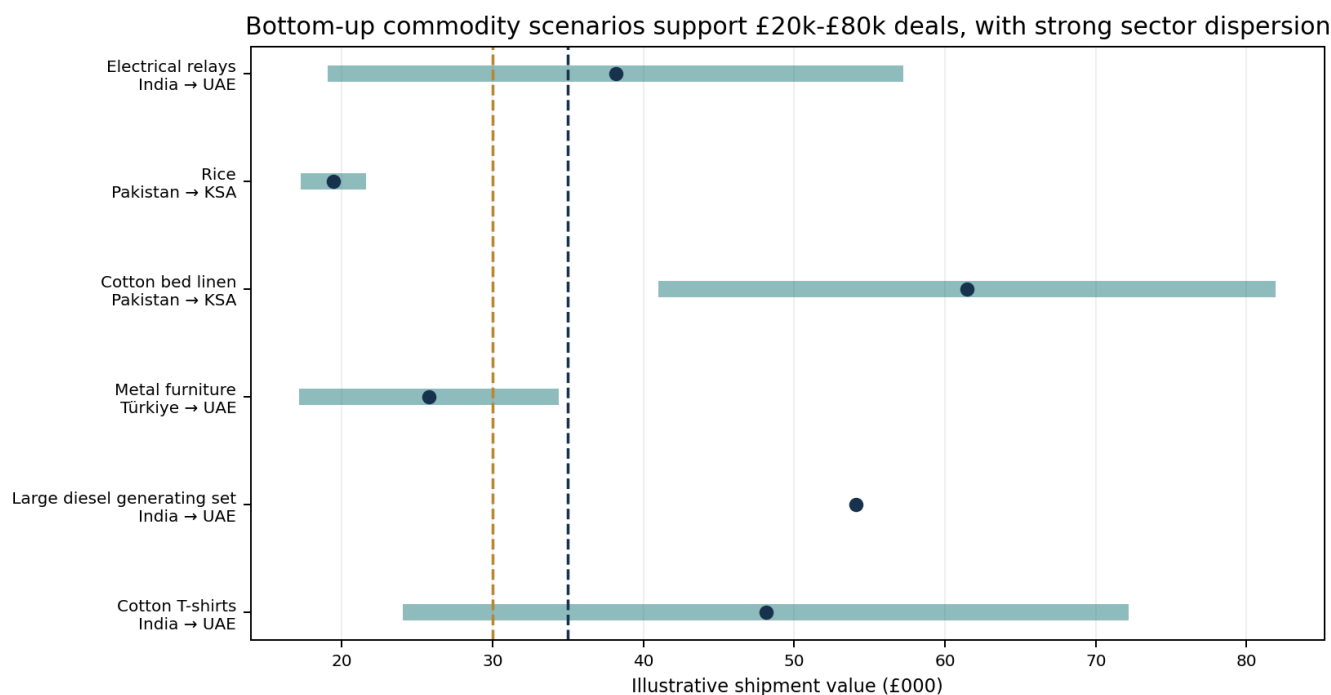


Figure 6. Illustrative shipment ranges based on customs unit values and explicitly stated planning quantities.

Shipment mode and arrangement

- **LCL versus FCL.** Maersk describes LCL as suitable for loads below 15 CBM or 2-3 pallets. CMA CGM lists a 20ft dry container at 33.2m³ and 28.25t payload, and a 40ft unit at 67.8m³ with payload up to 28.78t. These physical measures influence quantity, but not value density. [\[S15\]](#) [\[S16\]](#)
- **Forwarder versus direct carrier.** Forwarders consolidate LCL but also arrange FCL. There is no credible public basis for applying a universal forwarder discount or direct-carrier premium to deal value.
- **SME size.** Smaller SMEs often order less, but repeat importers may consolidate purchases, and an SME can import a single high-value machine. Turnover is not a usable substitute for invoice value.
- **Sector.** The planning examples range from roughly £17k-£22k for dense low-value goods to £55k+ for one generator and up to £82k for an illustrative textiles load. The early customer and sector mix therefore matters more than the tier label.

Reconciliation. The midpoint of the six illustrative bottom-up ranges is roughly in the low-£40k area, but this is not a sample mean: the goods were deliberately selected to span the target sectors. It supports a conservative £30k-£35k launch base rather than proving one.

5. Document maturity and transaction size

No credible public evidence proves eBL transactions are systematically larger

DCSA reported actual eBL adoption around 4% in 2024, up from 2.1% in 2022, and later described around 11% of bills as electronic in 2025. The FIT Alliance’s respondent survey found 49.2% using eBL in some capacity, 50% in the Middle East and 29.4% among freight forwarders. The difference between actual bill share and respondent usage illustrates measurement and selection effects. [S17] [S18] [S19]

The survey does provide one directional link: firms with more than 250 employees adopt eBL more frequently. However, it explicitly says **industry type is the strongest factor**. The first standards-based interoperable eBL transaction was completed only in May 2025, and DCSA identifies platform fragmentation as a prior constraint. [S18] [S20]

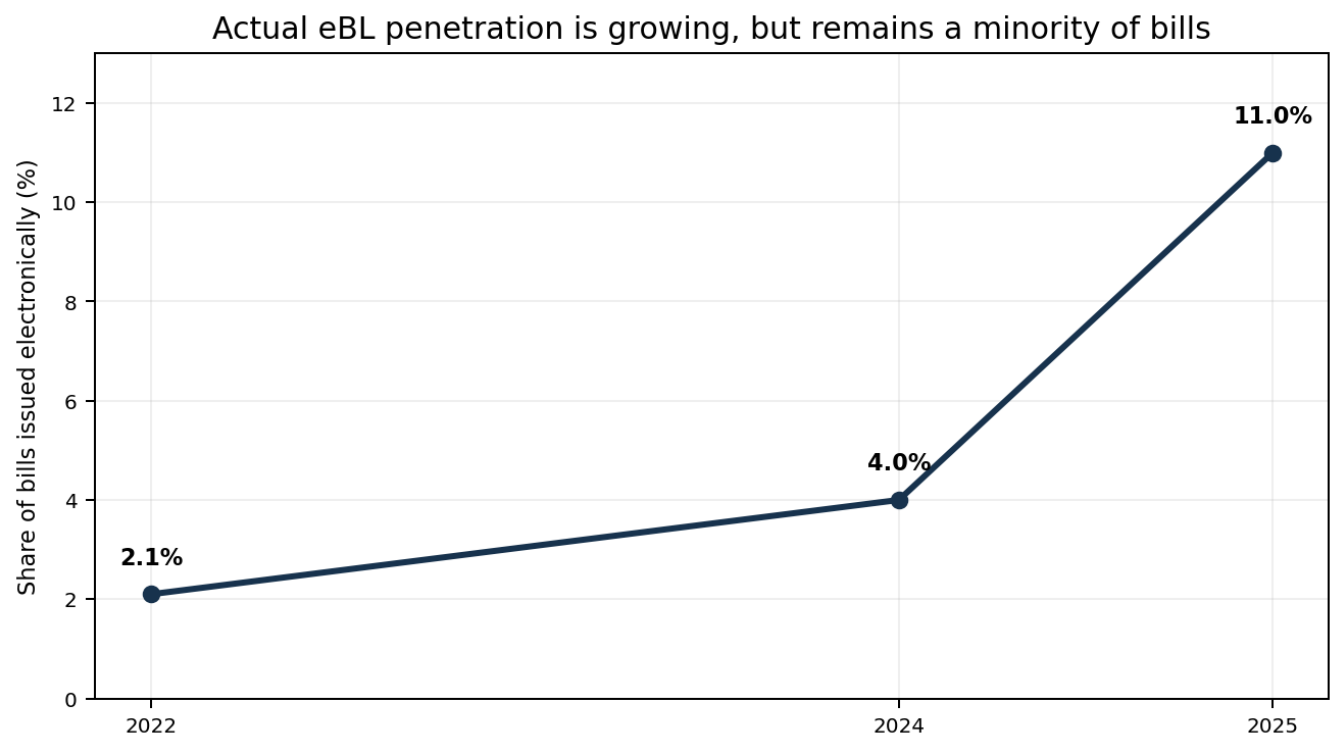


Figure 17. Actual eBL share increased rapidly from a low base; this is adoption evidence, not transaction-value evidence.

Question	Evidence-backed answer	Modelling implication
Are Tier A deals necessarily larger?	No. Larger firms adopt more often, but industry is the stronger adoption factor and small transactions can use eBL rails.	Use only a modest launch-mix premium, not a structural hierarchy.
Are Tier C deals necessarily smaller?	No. Paper/original documents remain common and high-value goods can still use manual processes.	Do not force Tier C below Tier B. Screen small deals for affordability.
Does carrier/API verification imply FCL?	No. Carriers and forwarders support different shipment sizes and document flows.	Model shipment mode and sector separately from tier.

Question	Evidence-backed answer	Modelling implication
Will migration raise deal value?	Possibly, but migration changes the tier mix as much as it changes within-tier averages.	Use separate transaction-count migration assumptions; avoid double counting in average-value growth.

6. Tier-by-tier rationale

Tier A	£35,000 / \$47,000
Customer and document fit. A modest launch-mix premium is plausible because larger firms adopt eBL more often, but the evidence says industry type matters more than firm size. The premium is therefore deliberately small, not structural. Pricing fit. At the base value, the fee is £252.50 (0.72%). The percentage-fee minimum stops binding around £23,077. Trust and threshold. Base growth is 10%; the average crosses the £50,000 threshold in Y5.	
Tier B	£30,000 / \$41,000
Customer and document fit. This is the broadest launch tier: digital enough to verify efficiently, but not dependent on a fully interoperable eBL ecosystem. It aligns closely with India export-declaration and commodity-shipment proxies. Pricing fit. At the base value, the fee is £360.00 (1.20%). The percentage-fee minimum stops binding around £27,778. Trust and threshold. Base growth is 8%; the average crosses the £50,000 threshold in Not by Y5.	
Tier C	£30,000 / \$41,000
Customer and document fit. Paper documentation does not imply a small trade. A £30k base is retained because the all-in customer fee becomes punitive below roughly £25k-£30k and because larger manual deals remain commercially possible. Pricing fit. At the base value, the fee is £900.00 (3.00%). The percentage-fee minimum stops binding around £25,000. Trust and threshold. Base growth is 5%; the average crosses the £50,000 threshold in Not by Y5.	

What the Year-1 averages represent

The recommended bases assume a small, selected launch cohort: repeat mid-market SME importers/exporters or a forwarder-led cluster, with transactions screened for documentary suitability and willingness to prefund. They do not represent all customs declarations or all SMEs. Selection raises the expected average above the broad £16k declaration proxy, but limited trust and an early operating cap justify keeping the bases below exporter-oriented £79k-£84k proxies.

Planning concentration bands

Tier	Low / practical lower anchor	Base	High / practical upper anchor	Interpretation
Tier A	£25k	£35k	£50k	Selected digital-ready customers; high anchor reaches the current automatic-verdict cap.
Tier B	£20k	£30k	£45k	Broad API/carrier/issuer verification; lower values can remain attractive near the minimum fee.
Tier C	£25k	£30k	£45k	Manual fallback; £20k is retained only as a downside sensitivity because the fee reaches 4%.

These are practical planning bands, not statistical interquartile ranges.

7. Unit economics and customer affordability

Recommended-base fee check

Tier	Y1 deal	Y1 customer fee	Y1 all-in %	Y5 deal	Y5 fee	Y5 all-in %	Minimum-fee breakpoint
Tier A	£35,000	£252.50	0.72%	£51,244	£358.08	0.70%	£23,077
Tier B	£30,000	£360.00	1.20%	£40,815	£457.33	1.12%	£27,778
Tier C	£30,000	£900.00	3.00%	£36,465	£1,029.30	2.82%	£25,000

At the recommended Year-1 bases, Tier A costs 0.72% of the deal, Tier B 1.20%, and Tier C 3.00%. Tier A and B are comfortably below Escrow.com's 2.4% standard price for £5k-£50k general-merchandise transactions. Tier C is above standard escrow but below the 4.8% concierge rate; its value proposition must therefore rest on trade-document verification and controlled release, not generic escrow alone. [\[S23\]](#)

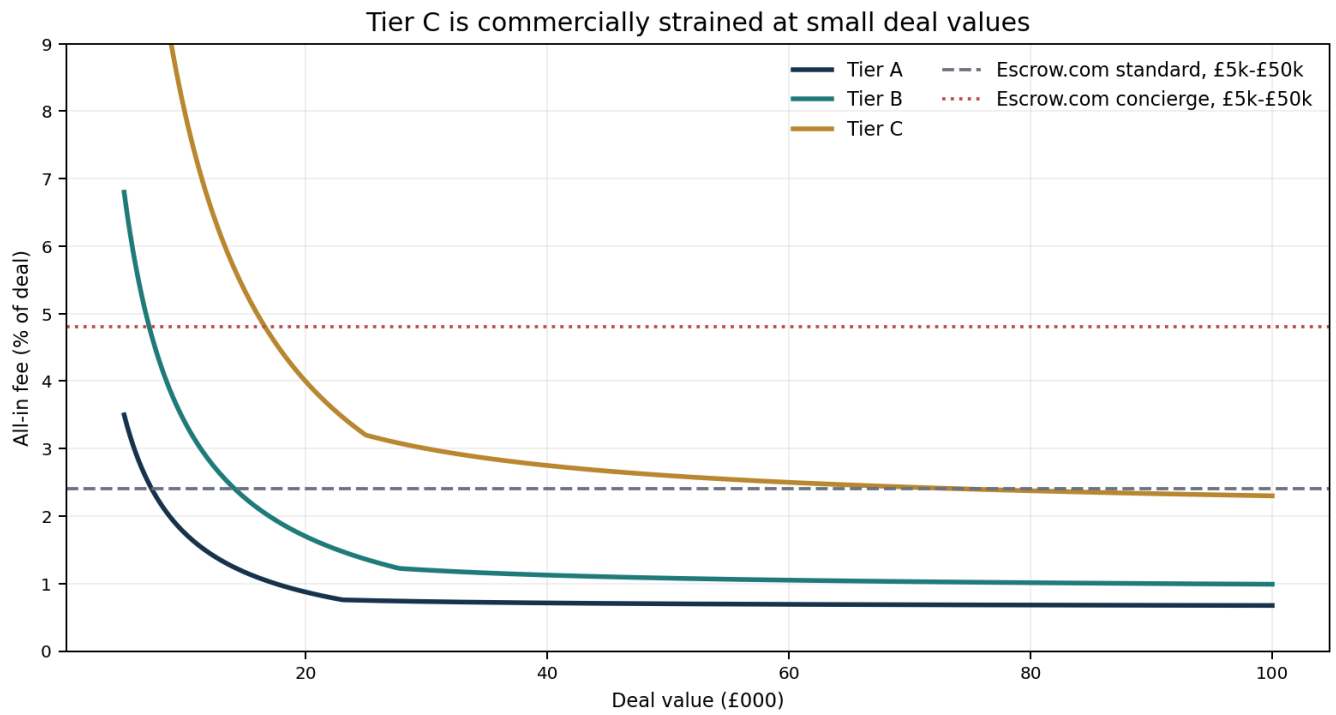


Figure 8. All-in customer fee percentages fall as minimum fees are diluted; Tier C is unattractive at very small values.

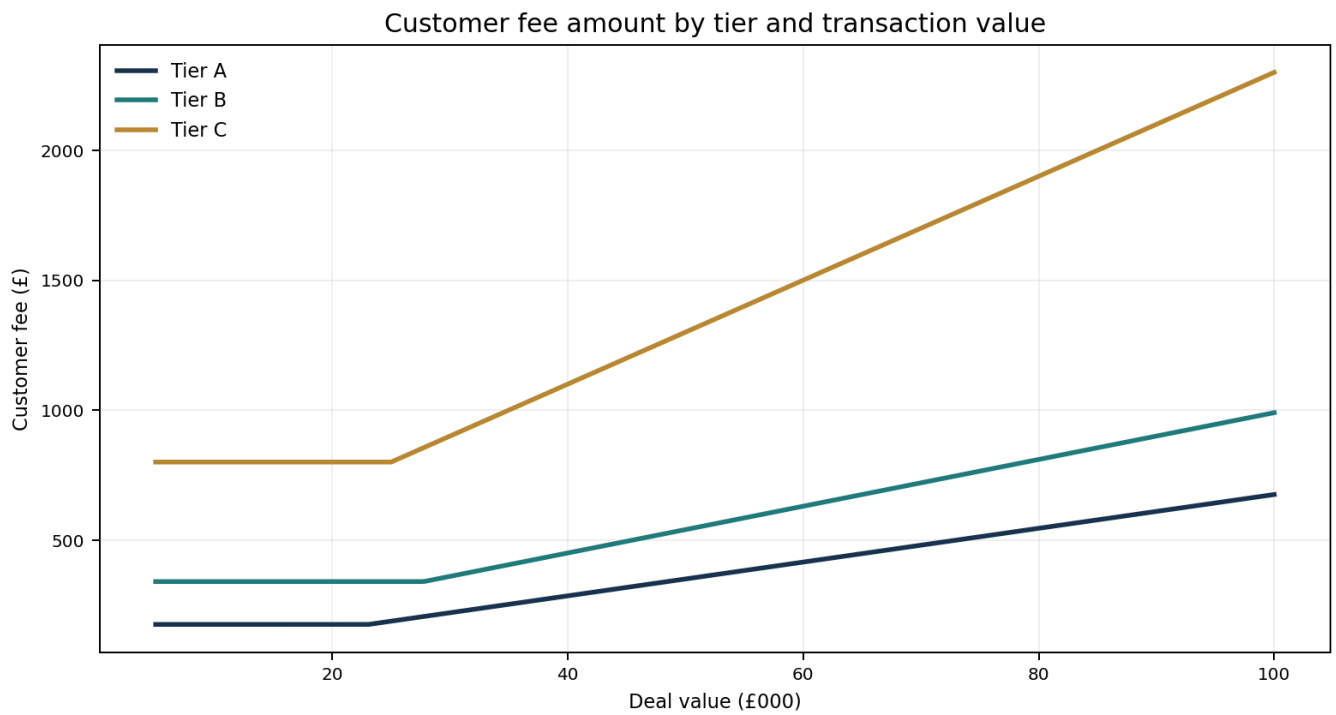


Figure 9. Absolute customer fee grows linearly after each percentage-fee breakpoint.

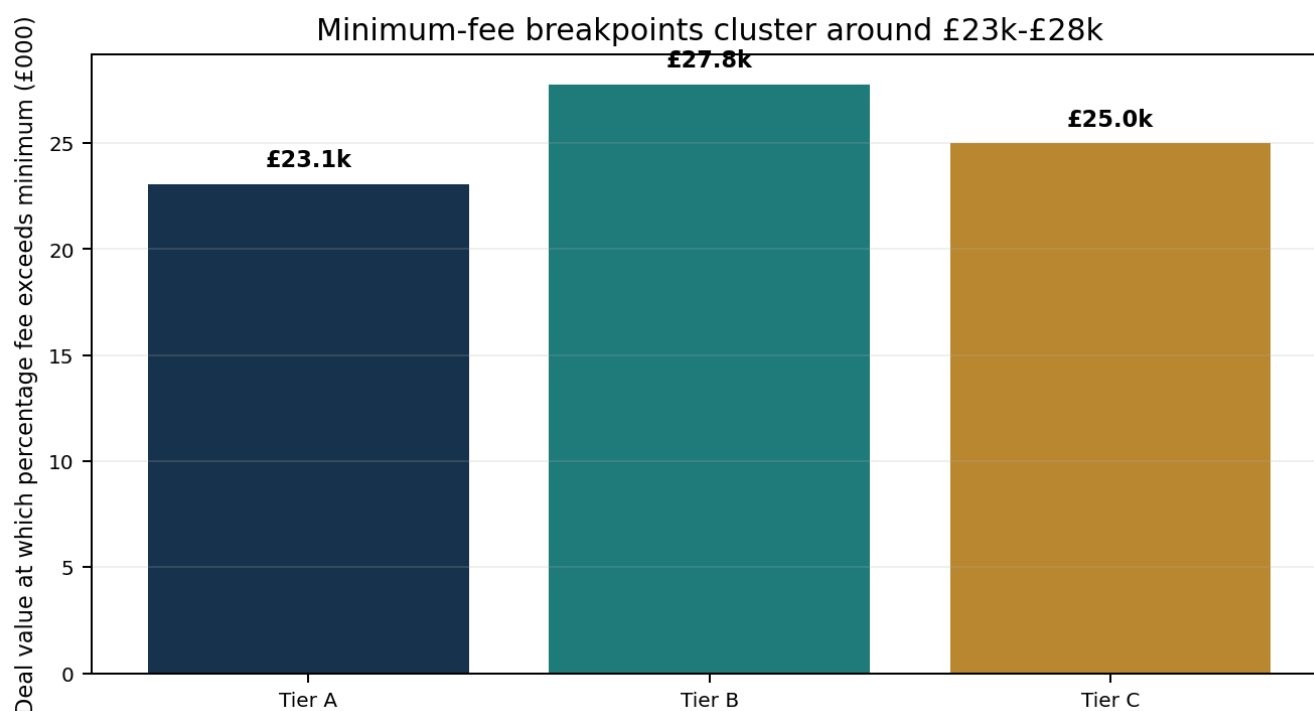


Figure 10. The escrow-rate minimum stops binding at approximately £23.1k, £27.8k and £25k for Tiers A, B and C.

Minimum deal size and internal cost

Public information cannot determine Blockmediary's internal variable cost. The correct break-even rule is:

If variable cost ≤ minimum escrow fee + document fee, any accepted deal covers variable cost.

Otherwise, minimum deal value = (variable cost – document fee) / escrow rate.

At the recommended Year-1 bases, the total fee revenue available to cover payment, compliance, verification and support costs is £252.50 for Tier A, £360 for Tier B and £900 for Tier C. A 50% contribution-margin target would cap variable costs at £126.25, £180 and £450 respectively. These are cost ceilings, not estimates of actual cost.

Comparable-product check at £30,000

Provider/product	Fee	Fee %	Scope	Source	Important limitation
Blockmediary Tier A	£220.00	0.73%	Prefunded escrow + tier-specific document verification	Company pricing assumption	Direct pricing comparison, but product is still differentiated by verification depth.
FAB export LC - illustrative unconfirmed	£262.12	0.87%	Advising + document checking + bill handling + international courier	[S25]	LC includes a bank undertaking and may involve collateral, confirmation, financing, FX and discrepancy charges; not a like-for-like substitute.
FAB import LC - illustrative digital application	£328.25	1.09%	3-month issuance + SWIFT + bill processing + international courier	[S24]	LC includes a bank undertaking and may involve collateral, confirmation, financing, FX and discrepancy charges; not a like-for-like substitute.

Provider/product	Fee	Fee %	Scope	Source	Important limitation
Blockmediary Tier B	£360.00	1.20%	Prefunded escrow + tier-specific document verification	Company pricing assumption	Direct pricing comparison, but product is still differentiated by verification depth.
FAB export LC - illustrative with minimum confirmation	£463.76	1.55%	Unconfirmed illustration plus minimum confirmation fee	[S25]	LC includes a bank undertaking and may involve collateral, confirmation, financing, FX and discrepancy charges; not a like-for-like substitute.
FAB import LC - illustrative paper application	£529.88	1.77%	Digital illustration plus paper application surcharge	[S24]	LC includes a bank undertaking and may involve collateral, confirmation, financing, FX and discrepancy charges; not a like-for-like substitute.
Escrow.com Standard	£720.00	2.40%	General merchandise escrow	[S23]	Does not establish equivalent documentary-trade verification.
Blockmediary Tier C	£900.00	3.00%	Prefunded escrow + tier-specific document verification	Company pricing assumption	Direct pricing comparison, but product is still differentiated by verification depth.
Escrow.com Concierge	£1,440.00	4.80%	General merchandise escrow with concierge service	[S23]	Higher-touch but not a bank undertaking or necessarily document-rule automation.

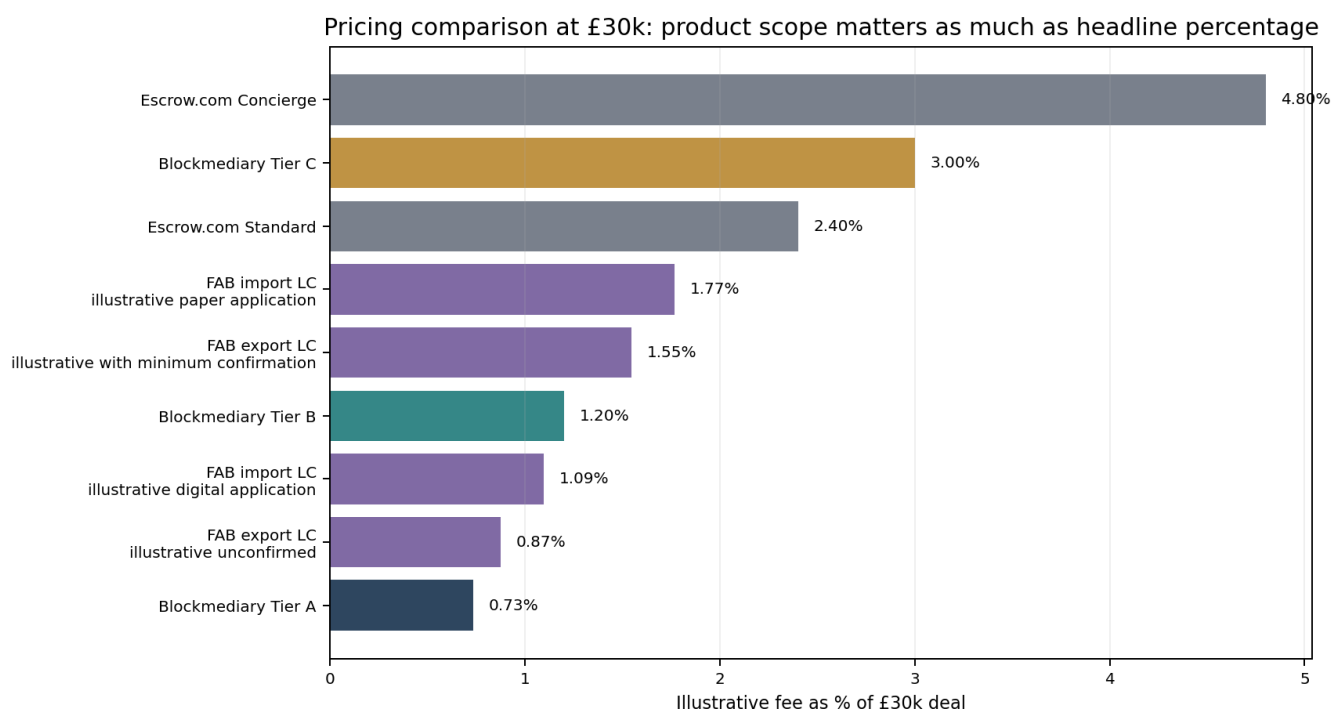


Figure 11. Illustrative fee percentages at £30k. Bank LC calculations use current FAB schedule components but are not like-for-like product comparisons.

FAB's import-LC schedule charges 0.16% per month on the first AED100k and 0.125% thereafter, with a minimum three-month period, plus fixed SWIFT, bill-processing and courier charges; a paper application adds AED1,000. The illustrative digital total at £30k is about 1.09%, and the paper application about 1.77%, before discrepancies, amendments, confirmation, financing, collateral opportunity cost or FX. An LC includes a bank undertaking, so it is not merely a cheaper or more expensive version of prefunded escrow. [S24] [S25]

Open-account trade can be cheaper in direct payment fees, but it shifts counterparty and documentary-performance risk to the buyer or seller. Blockmediary should be sold as a risk-control and workflow product, not as the cheapest payment rail.

8. Model implications

Replace the current shared £25k / 35% assumption

Tier	Y1 GMV/deal change	Y1 fee/deal change	Y5 GMV/deal change	Y5 fee/deal change	Average crosses £50k
Tier A	+40.0%	+34.7%	-38.3%	-36.6%	Y5
Tier B	+20.0%	+5.9%	-50.8%	-45.4%	Not by Y5
Tier C	+20.0%	+12.5%	-56.1%	-47.5%	Not by Y5

At a fixed transaction count, the new Year-1 bases increase GMV per deal by 40% for Tier A and 20% for Tier B/C versus the shared £25k assumption. Fee revenue per deal rises by about 34.7%, 5.9% and 12.5% respectively. By Year 5, however, recommended GMV per deal is 38%-56% lower and fee revenue per deal 37%-48% lower than the current £83,039 case. This materially reduces headline GMV but improves defensibility.

Recommended Year 1 is higher, but Year 5 is substantially lower than the current shared model

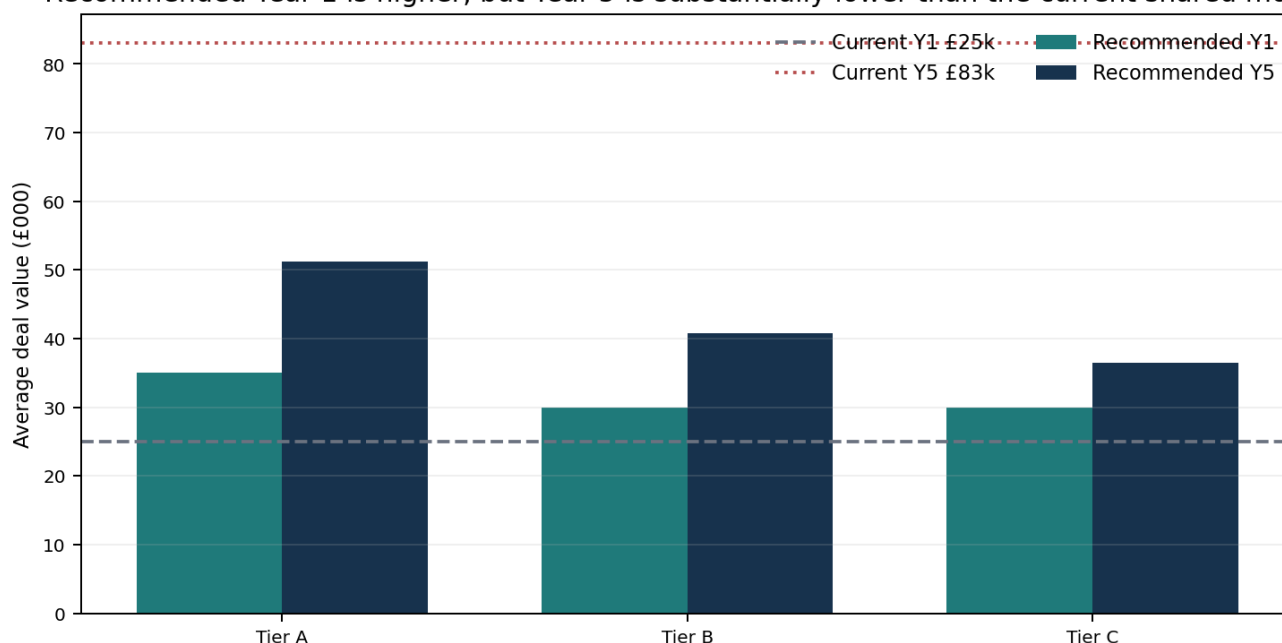


Figure 12. Recommended average deal values versus the current shared Year-1 and Year-5 assumptions.

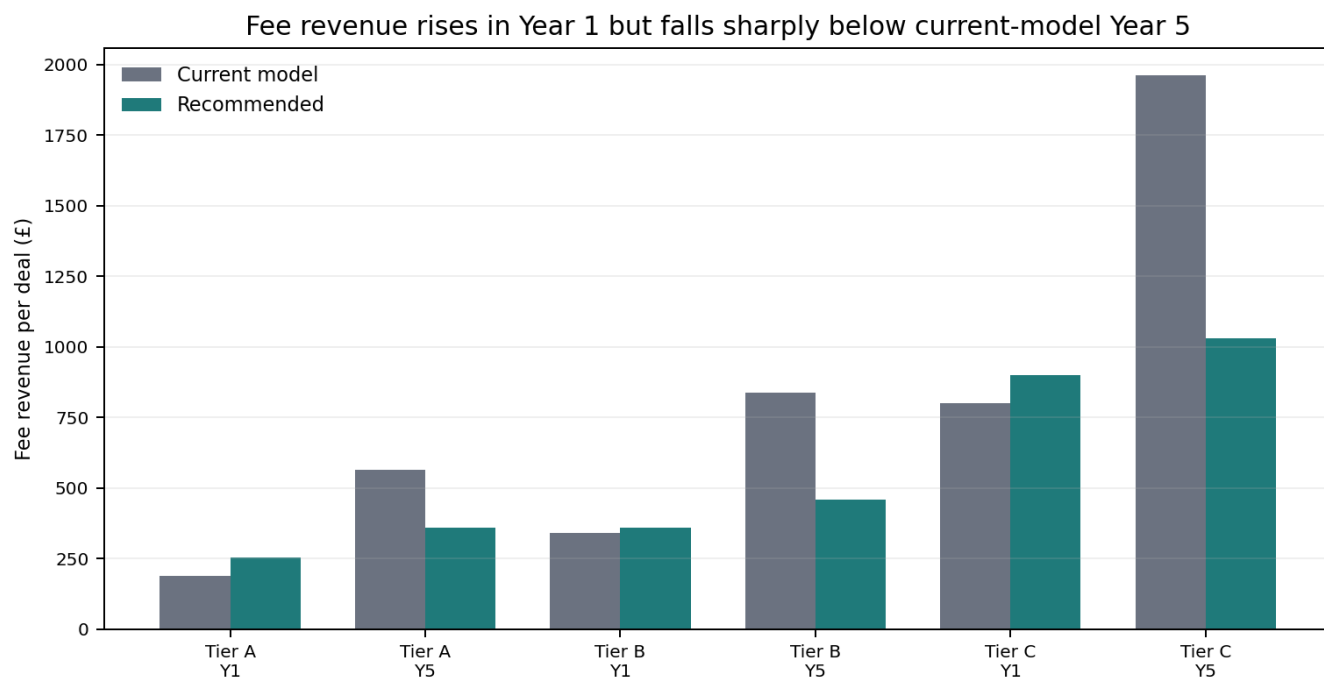


Figure 13. Per-deal fee revenue under the current and recommended assumptions.

£50,000 human-review threshold

The current model's average crosses the cap in Year 4. Under the base recommendation, Tier A crosses in Year 5; Tier B and Tier C do not cross by Year 5. Under high sensitivities, Tier A begins at £50k in Year 1, Tier B crosses in Year 2, and Tier C in Year 3.

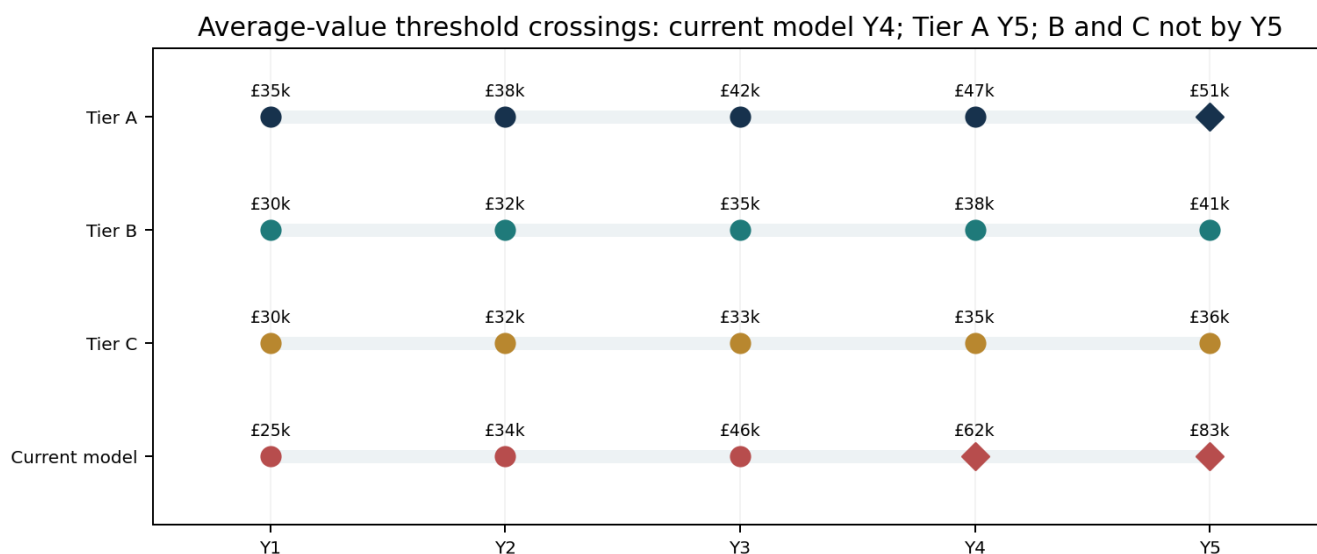


Figure 16. Average-value threshold status across five years. Diamonds indicate values at or above £50k.

Do not model the threshold as a commercial maximum. Average values below £50k can still contain a meaningful tail above the cap. Human review is triggered deal by deal, so operating cost must use the value distribution, not only the average.

Review workload should be modelled as a separate operating-cost module



Do not force average deal values below £50k merely to suppress reviews; cost the tail of the distribution explicitly.

Figure 20. Required separate review-cost calculation. The accompanying workbook includes an input template.

Effects on GMV, revenue, margin and workload

Model output	Effect	Required treatment
GMV	Higher in Y1 than the existing £25k base, lower in later years than the 35% growth path.	Apply tier-specific average values to transaction counts; avoid applying one blended value to every tier.
Fee revenue	Tracks tier fee curves, not GMV one-for-one because minimum fees bind at lower values.	Calculate each tier separately using max(rate × value, minimum) + document fee.
Tier margin	Cannot be established without verification, compliance, payment and review costs.	Add variable cost per normal deal and incremental cost per above-cap review.
Operating workload	Fewer base-average crossings than the current model, but tails and manual Tier C packs can still dominate labour.	Model pages/documents, exception rate, review time, rework and SLA separately.
Tier migration	Movement C → B/A can raise the overall company average while slowing Tier C's own average.	Use migration in the transaction-count mix; do not double count it as within-tier growth.

9. Research gaps and primary validation plan

The public evidence is adequate for a conservative base case but not for a high-confidence distribution. The missing information is concentrated in launch-customer behaviour and operating cost.

Unanswered question	Why public data are insufficient	Recommended primary research	Minimum useful output
Actual invoice distribution by target corridor and sector	Customs and trade totals do not link shipment, invoice, SME status and document set.	15-20 SME importer/exporter interviews plus anonymised invoice samples.	Median, mean, 25th/75th/90th percentiles, repeat frequency and payment terms.
Forwarder-led cluster distribution	Forwarders consolidate LCL and book FCL; public carrier data lack commercial invoice values.	Obtain 6-12 months of anonymised job-level data from two UAE forwarders.	Invoice value, mode, container status, corridor, sector, direct/forwarded and document type.
Tier A versus paper transaction values	eBL providers publish adoption and case studies, not value distributions.	Interview two eBL platforms and two carriers; request anonymised value bands or shipment-size proxies.	Value or TEU/weight distribution by eBL and paper, controlling for sector.
Manual-review unit cost	External fee schedules do not reveal Blockmediary's workflow or quality-control burden.	Time-and-motion pilot with documentary examiners.	Minutes per pack, discrepancy/rework rate, pages/documents, escalation and loaded cost.
Willingness to pay and minimum viable deal size	Competitor prices are not proof of customer willingness to pay for this specific product.	Conjoint or price-ladder testing with 20-30 target users.	Conversion probability by tier, deal value, fee and trust mechanism.
Above-cap review share	An average does not identify distribution tails.	Collect all quoted and onboarded deal values from first pilot cohort.	Share above £50k and expected reviews per 100 deals by tier.

Single most valuable next step. Secure anonymised, transaction-level data from one UAE freight forwarder covering at least 200 recent SME jobs, including invoice value, sector, corridor, mode, FCL/LCL, document format and document count. This one dataset would validate the Year-1 distribution, the tier relationship and the review workload more efficiently than additional macro research.

10. Final decision statement

Recommended numbers

Tier	Year-1 average	USD comparison	Annual growth	Year-5 average	Confidence
Tier A	£35,000	\$47,000	10%	£51,000	Medium-low
Tier B	£30,000	\$41,000	8%	£41,000	Medium
Tier C	£30,000	\$41,000	5%	£36,500	Medium-low

Three strongest supporting facts

1. India's official export values and annual Shipping Bill count imply about £30k per non-petroleum export document and £35k per all-merchandise export document—close to the proposed launch bases. [\[S7\]](#) [\[S8\]](#)
2. A targeted Dubai maritime-port ratio implies roughly £39k per customs declaration, while the much broader all-Dubai ratio is about £16k and chamber certificate proxies are about £79k-£84k. The proposed £30k-£35k values sit conservatively within that hierarchy. [\[S2\]](#) [\[S3\]](#) [\[S4\]](#) [\[S5\]](#) [\[S6\]](#)
3. eBL evidence shows larger firms adopt more often but industry type is the stronger determinant, so only a modest Tier A premium is justified and no strict tier-size ordering is defensible. [\[S18\]](#)

Three greatest uncertainties

1. The true launch-cohort median, quartiles and right tail by sector, corridor and tier.
2. The extent to which repeat customers entrust larger transactions to Blockmediary, separate from nominal trade growth.
3. The actual time and cost of manual/document exception review, especially above £50k.

Overall confidence: medium-low. The base case is credible for planning and investor discussion because it is conservative and triangulated. Confidence should be upgraded only after transaction-level forwarder or pilot data are obtained.

Appendix A. Evidence table

Finding or input	Value	Geography/sector	Source	Date	Quality	Limitation	Type
Official exchange rate	USD/AED 3.6725; GBP/AED 4.959487; derived GBP/USD 1.3504	UAE / FX	[S1]	10 August 2026	High	Single-date conversion; future model years retain constant FX for comparability.	Observed + derived
Dubai customs declarations	More than 26.5m in 2023; 22.5m in 2022	Dubai / all customs	[S2]	21 Feb 2024	High	A declaration is not necessarily one commercial transaction.	Observed
DIEZ trade and Dubai share	AED282bn; 13.5% of Dubai non-oil trade in 2023	Dubai economic zones	[S3]	12 Aug 2024	High	Zone trade mix differs from the whole market.	Observed
Broad Dubai value per declaration proxy	£15,894 / \$21,464	Dubai / all modes	[S2] [S3]	2023 data	Medium-low	Numerator is inferred from a zone share; declarations include courier, re-exports, transit and multiple declarations per commercial deal.	Derived proxy
Hamriyah + Deira customs declarations	AED12.133bn across 62,454 declarations	Dubai / maritime	[S4]	24 Dec 2023	High	Nine months and only two ports.	Observed
Hamriyah + Deira value per declaration proxy	£39,172 / \$52,899	Dubai / maritime	[S4]	Q1-Q3 2023	Medium	Only two smaller ports and nine months; excludes Jebel Ali; declaration is not necessarily one trade deal.	Derived proxy
Dubai Chamber export/re-export proxy 2024	£78,909 per certificate of origin	Dubai Chamber members	[S5]	20 Jan 2025	Medium-low	Includes large firms; a certificate of origin is not a one-to-one transaction denominator.	Derived proxy
Dubai Chamber export/re-export proxy 2025	£84,351 per certificate of origin	Dubai Chamber members	[S6]	14 Jan 2026	Medium-low	Includes large firms; a certificate of origin is not a one-to-one transaction denominator.	Derived proxy
Implied Chamber proxy growth 2024-2025	6.9%	Dubai Chamber members	[S5] [S6]	2024-2025	Medium-low	One-year movement in a proxy, not a forecast or same-deal cohort.	Derived proxy
India customs form volumes	5.5m Bills of Entry and 9.2m Shipping Bills annually; ~99% coverage	India / all trade	[S7]	Updated 2 Jun 2026	High	Approximate annual counts; documents may not map one-to-one to invoices.	Observed
India FY2024-25 merchandise trade	\$437.42bn exports; \$374.08bn non-petroleum exports; \$720.24bn imports	India / merchandise	[S8]	16 Apr 2025	High	Includes large firms and sectors outside target scope.	Observed
India non-petroleum exports per Shipping Bill	£30,109 / \$40,661	India / non-petroleum exports	[S7] [S8]	FY2024-25 / current count	Medium	Trade total and annual document count are broad national figures and may not cover identical periods; Shipping Bill is not necessarily one invoice.	Derived proxy
India all merchandise exports per Shipping Bill	£35,208 / \$47,546	India / exports	[S7] [S8]	FY2024-25 / current count	Medium	Includes oil, large corporates and sectors outside Blockmediary targets; Shipping Bill is not necessarily one invoice.	Derived proxy
India imports per Bill of Entry	£96,970 / \$130,953	India / imports	[S7] [S8]	FY2024-25 / current count	Medium-low	Includes oil, gold and large industrial imports; Bills of Entry can aggregate or split commercial transactions.	Derived proxy
Cotton T-shirt customs unit value	\$6.50 per item	India → UAE / textiles	[S9]	2023 data	Medium	Customs unit value is an aggregate across qualities and contracts; shipment quantity is a planning assumption.	Derived unit value
Cotton T-shirt planning shipment	£24,063-£72,189	India → UAE / textiles	[S9]	2023 data	Low	Planning shipment of 5,000-15,000 items.	Assumption + derived
Large diesel generator unit value	£54,111 per unit	India → UAE / manufactured equipment	[S10]	2023 data	Medium	HS line aggregates different specifications; one-item assumption may not map to one invoice.	Derived unit value
Metal furniture planning shipment	£17,191-£34,382	Türkiye → UAE / furniture	[S11]	2023 data	Low	Planning load of 6-12 tonnes.	Assumption + derived
Cotton bed-linen planning shipment	£40,966-£81,932	Pakistan → KSA / textiles	[S12]	2023 data	Low	Planning load of 5-10 tonnes.	Assumption + derived
Rice planning shipment	£17,295-£21,619	Pakistan → KSA / low-value-density proxy	[S13]	2023 data	Low	Rice is outside the primary target sectors and is included only as a low-value-density floor proxy.	Assumption + derived
Electrical-relay planning shipment	£19,082-£57,247	India → UAE / electronics	[S14]	2023 data	Low	Planning shipment of 0.5-1.5 tonnes.	Assumption + derived
LCL rule of thumb	Less than 15 CBM or 2-3 pallets	Ocean freight	[S15]	Accessed 11 Aug 2026	Medium	Mode threshold, not a transaction-value statistic.	Observed guidance

Finding or input	Value	Geography/sector	Source	Date	Quality	Limitation	Type
Standard dry-container capacity	20ft: 33.2m³ / 28.25t; 40ft: 67.8m³ / up to 28.78t	Ocean freight	[S16]	Accessed 11 Aug 2026	High	Physical capacity alone does not determine cargo value.	Observed specification
eBL share of bills	2.1% in 2022; around 4% in 2024; around 11% in 2025	Global container shipping	[S17] [S19]	2022-2025	Medium-high	Share of bills, not share of trade value or transaction-size distribution.	Observed
FIT eBL adoption survey	49.2% respondent adoption; Middle East 50%; forwarders 29.4%	Global / surveyed trade participants	[S18]	12 Dec 2024	Medium	Survey adoption is not actual bill share and may reflect selection bias.	Observed survey
Firm size and eBL adoption	Firms >250 employees adopt more; industry type is the strongest factor	Global / surveyed firms	[S18]	12 Dec 2024	Medium	No transaction-value distribution by document format.	Observed survey
eBL interoperability maturity	First standards-based interoperable transaction completed 15 May 2025	Global container shipping	[S20]	15 May 2025	High	Milestone does not show average transaction values.	Observed
World merchandise trade-volume outlook	+1.9% in 2026; +2.6% in 2027	Global merchandise trade	[S21]	19 Mar 2026	High	Volume growth is not average transaction-value growth.	Observed forecast
UAE inflation outlook	1.6% in 2025; around 2% medium term	UAE	[S22]	2 Oct 2025	High	Consumer inflation is only a partial proxy for traded-goods values.	Observed forecast
Escrow.com fee benchmark	2.4% standard / 4.8% concierge for £5k-£50k	General merchandise escrow	[S23]	Accessed 11 Aug 2026	Medium-high	Not necessarily equivalent documentary-trade verification.	Observed price
FAB import-LC fee schedule	0.16%/month first AED100k; 0.125% thereafter; 3-month minimum; additional fixed fees	UAE / documentary credit	[S24]	Current schedule	High	LC includes bank undertaking and may add confirmation, financing, FX and discrepancy fees.	Observed price
UAE-India non-oil trade corridor	About AED180bn (\$49bn); Q1 2023 +24.7% year-on-year	UAE ↔ India	[S26]	25 May 2023	High	No transaction or shipment denominator.	Observed corridor total
UAE-Türkiye bilateral trade corridor	More than \$20bn in 2023; five-year target \$40bn	UAE ↔ Türkiye	[S27]	9 Oct 2024	High	No transaction or shipment denominator; one-off growth reflects CEPA effects.	Observed corridor total
Saudi-Pakistan bilateral trade corridor	\$5.4bn	KSA ↔ Pakistan	[S28]	10 Oct 2024	High	No transaction or shipment denominator.	Observed corridor total
Tier A Year-1 planning range	£25k-£50k; base £35k	Blockmediary launch mix	Triangulated recommendation	11 August 2026	Medium-low	Planning range, not empirical IQR.	Recommendation
Tier B Year-1 planning range	£20k-£45k; base £30k	Blockmediary launch mix	Triangulated recommendation	11 August 2026	Medium	Planning range, not empirical IQR.	Recommendation
Tier C Year-1 planning range	£25k-£45k; base £30k	Blockmediary launch mix	Triangulated recommendation	11 August 2026	Medium-low	Planning range, not empirical IQR; £20k low sensitivity is commercially stressed.	Recommendation

Appendix B. Direct source links

All links were accessed or verified for this report. PDF links may open directly in a browser.

S1	Central Bank of the UAE. Central Bank of the UAE - Exchange rates against UAE dirham. 10 Aug 2026 (last updated). https://www.centralbank.ae/umbraco/Surface/Exchange/GetExchangeRateAllCurrency Used for: Official AED rates used to derive GBP/USD: USD/AED 3.6725; GBP/AED 4.959487.
S2	Government of Dubai Media Office. Hamdan bin Mohammed highlights Dubai as a global trade hub. 21 Feb 2024. https://www.mediaoffice.ae/en/news/2024/february/21-02/hamdan-bin-mohammed-highlights-dubai Used for: Dubai Customs processed more than 26.5m declarations in 2023, up from 22.5m.
S3	Government of Dubai Media Office. DIEZ record trade results in 2023. 12 Aug 2024. https://www.mediaoffice.ae/en/news/2024/august/12-08/diez Used for: AED282bn total trade represented 13.5% of Dubai non-oil trade.
S4	Dubai Customs. Hamriyah and Deira ports customs declaration value. 24 Dec 2023. https://www.dubaicustoms.gov.ae/en/mobile/Pages/newsdetails.aspx?itemid=2005 Used for: 62,454 declarations with AED12.133bn value in first nine months of 2023.
S5	Government of Dubai Media Office. Dubai Chamber 2024 performance. 20 Jan 2025. https://www.mediaoffice.ae/en/news/2025/january/20-01/new-companies-join-dubai-chamber-of-commerce Used for: AED309.6bn exports/re-exports and 791,115 certificates of origin in 2024.
S6	Government of Dubai Media Office. Dubai Chamber 2025 performance. 14 Jan 2026. https://cd1.mediaoffice.ae/en/news/2026/january/14-01/dubai-chambers-of-commerce-for-the-first-time Used for: AED356.5bn exports/re-exports and 852,184 certificates of origin in 2025.
S7	National Informatics Centre, Government of India. Indian Customs EDI System performance indicators. Updated 2 Jun 2026. https://www.nic.gov.in/project/ices/ Used for: ICES handles approximately 99% of India trade; 5.5m Bills of Entry and 9.2m Shipping Bills annually.
S8	Press Information Bureau, Government of India. India trade performance FY2024-25. 16 Apr 2025. https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2122016&lang=2@=3 Used for: Merchandise exports \$437.42bn; non-petroleum exports \$374.08bn; imports \$720.24bn.
S9	World Bank WITS / UN Comtrade. UAE imports of cotton T-shirts by partner, 2023. 2023 data; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://wits.worldbank.org/trade/comtrade/en/country/ARE/year/2023/tradeflow/Imports/partner/ALL/product/610910 Used for: India: \$188.260m and 28.9669m items.
S10	World Bank WITS / UN Comtrade. UAE imports of large diesel generating sets by partner, 2023. 2023 data; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://wits.worldbank.org/trade/comtrade/en/country/ARE/year/2023/tradeflow/Imports/partner/ALL/product/850213 Used for: India: \$73.658m and 1,008 items.
S11	World Bank WITS / UN Comtrade. UAE imports of metal furniture by partner, 2023. 2023 data; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://wits.worldbank.org/trade/comtrade/en/country/ARE/year/2023/tradeflow/Imports/partner/ALL/product/940320 Used for: Türkiye: \$5.624m and 1.45356m kg.
S12	World Bank WITS / UN Comtrade. Saudi imports of cotton bed linen by partner, 2023. 2023 data; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://wits.worldbank.org/trade/comtrade/en/country/SAU/year/2023/tradeflow/Imports/partner/ALL/product/630231 Used for: Pakistan: \$3.426m and 309,679 kg.
S13	World Bank WITS / UN Comtrade. Saudi imports of rice by partner, 2023. 2023 data; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://wits.worldbank.org/trade/comtrade/en/country/SAU/year/2023/tradeflow/Imports/partner/ALL/product/1006 Used for: Pakistan: \$141.539m and 121.201m kg.
S14	World Bank WITS / UN Comtrade. UAE imports of electrical relays by partner, 2023. 2023 data; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://wits.worldbank.org/trade/comtrade/en/country/ARE/year/2023/tradeflow/Imports/partner/ALL/product/853649 Used for: India: \$4.995m and 96,911 kg.
S15	Maersk. What is LCL in ocean shipping?. Accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://www.maersk.com/support/faqs/what-is-lcl-in-ocean-shipping Used for: LCL described as suitable for less than 15 CBM or 2-3 pallets.

S16	CMA CGM. Container specifications. Accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://www.cma-cgm.com/products-services/containers Used for: 20ft nominal capacity 33.2m3 and payload 28.25t; 40ft 67.8m3 and payload up to 28.78t.
S17	Digital Container Shipping Association. DCSA five years of impact. 2024 data; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://dcsa.org/about-us/5-years-dcsa Used for: eBL adoption around 4% in 2024, up from 2.1% in 2022.
S18	FIT Alliance. FIT Alliance 2024 eBL survey. 12 Dec 2024. https://www.fit-alliance.org/post/press-release-fit-alliance-s-2024-ebl-survey-shows-steady-rise-of-electronic-bill-of-lading-adopti Used for: 49.2% respondent adoption; Middle East 50%; forwarders 29.4%; firms over 250 employees adopt more, but industry type is the strongest factor.
S19	Digital Container Shipping Association. Soft barriers to eBL adoption. 2026; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://dcsa.org/newsroom/understanding-soft-barriers-to-digital-adoption Used for: Around 11% of bills of lading were electronic as of 2025.
S20	Digital Container Shipping Association. First standards-based interoperable eBL transaction. 15 May 2025. https://dcsa.org/newsroom/ebl-interoperability-milestone Used for: First successful standards-based interoperable eBL transaction; platform fragmentation had constrained adoption.
S21	World Trade Organization. Global Trade Outlook and Statistics. 19 Mar 2026. https://www.wto.org/english/news_e/news26_e/stat_19mar26_329_e.htm Used for: World merchandise trade volume forecast: +1.9% in 2026 and +2.6% in 2027.
S22	International Monetary Fund. UAE 2025 Article IV mission statement. 2 Oct 2025. https://www.imf.org/en/news/articles/2025/10/02/pr-25326-united-arab-emirates-imf-staff-completes-2025-article-iv-mission Used for: UAE inflation projected at 1.6% in 2025 and around 2% over the medium term.
S23	Escrow.com. Escrow.com fee calculator. Accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://www.escrow.com/fee-calculator Used for: Pounds sterling: 2.4% standard and 4.8% concierge for £5,000.01-£50,000; 1.9% and 3.8% for £50,000.01-£200,000.
S24	First Abu Dhabi Bank. Import Letter of Credit - Key Facts Statement. Current schedule; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://www.bankfab.com/-/media/fab-uds/business-banking/key-facts-statements/documents/import-letter-of-credit-en.pdf?view=1 Used for: Issuance 0.16%/month first AED100k, 0.125% thereafter, minimum 3 months/AED600; paper application AED1,000; SWIFT issuance AED500; international courier AED265; bill processing AED200.
S25	First Abu Dhabi Bank. Export Letter of Credit - Key Facts Statement. Current schedule; accessed 11 Aug 2026. https://www.bankfab.com/-/media/fab-uds/business-banking/key-facts-statements/documents/export-letter-of-credit-en.pdf?view=1 Used for: Advising AED300; confirmation minimum AED1,000; document checking AED250; bill handling 0.15% minimum AED500; international courier AED250.
S26	UAE Ministry of Economy. UAE-India trade partnership. 25 May 2023. https://www.moec.gov.ae/en/-/h.e.-bin-touq-uae-india-partnership-a-driver-for-economic-growth-that-creates-trade-investment-opportunities-for-over-3.8-billion-people Used for: Non-oil trade about AED180bn (\$49bn), up 10% from 2021; Q1 2023 growth 24.7% year-on-year.
S27	Republic of Türkiye Ministry of Trade. Türkiye-UAE bilateral trade. 9 Oct 2024. https://ticaret.gov.tr/haberler/ticaret-bakani-bolat-dubai-is-insanlari-heyetiyle-bir-araya-geldi Used for: Bilateral trade exceeded \$20bn in 2023, up 107%; stated five-year target \$40bn.
S28	Saudi Press Agency. Saudi-Pakistani Business Forum. 10 Oct 2024. https://www.spa.gov.sa/en/N2186500 Used for: Bilateral trade volume reached \$5.4bn.